CĀRVĀKA / LOKĀYATA — CONTINUOUS AT-A-GLANCE MASTER FLOW

source problem -> perception only -> three doors -> hidden condition -> self-refutation -> Nyāya reply -> testimony ledger -> four elements -> body-self -> transcendent denials -> ethics -> synthesis

Read the numbered rail downward. Stage 00 fixes what may be asserted, stages 02 to 07 carry the theory of knowledge, stages 08 to 11 derive the ontology and ethics from it, and stage 12 supplies the comparison, the PYQ rail and the answer spine. The final subordinate node is optional enrichment only.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW · ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA · ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

Cārvāka master flow · core before optional enrichment · prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 SOURCE-CRITICAL ENTRY: WHAT MAY BE ASSERTED

CĀRVĀKA · LOKĀYATA · BĀRHASPATYA | BṚHASPATI-SŪTRA LOST | HOSTILE DOXOGRAPHY | ABOUT A DOZEN QUOTED FRAGMENTS | JAYARĀŚI = LIMIT-CASE, NOT SPOKESMAN | WRITE: STANDARD RECONSTRUCTION

NO SYSTEMATIC MATERIALIST TREATISE SURVIVES

Opponent compendia: Mādhava's Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha, Śaṃkara, Jayanta Bhaṭṭa, Śāntarakṣita, Haribhadra, Kṛṣṇa Miśra → **Quoted aphorisms and verses, preserved only inside refutations** → **One surviving text-witness: Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa, Tattvopaplavasiṃha — radical scepticism, contested affiliation**

THE THREE NAMES, DECODED

- Cārvāka — standard school label; the 'chewing' and 'sweet-worded' etymologies are doxographers' explanations, not settled history
- Lokāyata — the worldly or popular doctrine; this-worldly, never world-renouncing
- Bārhaspatya — 'of Bṛhaspati', the traditional founder whose attributed Sūtra is lost

WHY THE SOURCES STILL WORK

- Independent hostile witnesses converge on the same doctrinal core, which fixes what may be asserted
- Hostile transmission exaggerates the weak points and omits the strong ones, so caricature must be filtered out
- Jayarāśi attacks even perception, so he cannot be used to state the school's defining thesis

EXAMINER CONSEQUENCE

- Both overstatements fail: 'the Bṛhaspati-sūtra proves it' and 'the sources are hostile, so nothing can be said'
- One qualifying clause in the introduction protects every later claim in the answer

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Reconstruction precedes doctrine, because what the school is allowed to be said to hold is fixed by what convergent hostile testimony can carry.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka, also called Lokāyata or Bārhaspatya, is the Veda-rejecting materialist tradition whose positive system survives only through its critics, so its doctrines must be stated as a cautious doxographical reconstruction.

01

STAGE 01 CLASSIFICATION, LOCATION AND EVIDENCE GRADING

NĀSTIKA IN BOTH SENSES | VEDIC AUTHORITY = PRIMARY TEST | AFTERLIFE DENIAL = SECONDARY | NĀSTIKA ≠ ATHEIST | AJITA KESAKAMBALĪ AS COMPARATOR

TEST	CĀRVĀKA	JAINISM AND BUDDHISM	SĀṂKHYA AND MĪMĀṂSĀ
Authority of the Veda	Rejected — the primary criterion of nāstika	Rejected — nāstika on this criterion	Accepted — therefore āstika
Existence after death	Denied — the secondary sense of nāstika	Accepted — āstika on this second sense	Accepted
Creator God	Denied, on epistemic grounds	Creator denied, without materialism	Non-theistic yet orthodox

HISTORICAL LOCATION — HANDLE WITH CARE

- Anti-ritual and naturalist currents appear in epic, Buddhist, Jaina and Brahmanical reports before later systematisation
- Ajita Kesakambalī is an important early materialist comparator, not proof that every early naturalist belonged to one organised school

EVIDENCE GRADING USED THROUGHOUT

- Attested: convergent doctrine reported by independent witnesses
- Analysis: reconstruction that goes beyond any single report
- Contested: attribution disputes such as chance-theory, the crude/refined contrast and Jayarāśi's affiliation

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The classification is decided by attitude to Vedic authority, which is why non-theism alone can never settle whether a school is orthodox.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka is unorthodox first because it rejects the authority of the Veda and only secondarily because it denies survival after death, so translating nāstika as atheist misplaces the whole classification.

02

STAGE 02 THE EPISTEMIC GATE: PERCEPTION ALONE

PERCEPTION (PRATYAKṢA) ALONE | EXTERNAL (BĀHYA) | INTERNAL (MĀNASA) | INFERENCE AND TESTIMONY REFUSED | AWARENESS IS NOT DENIED | ONTOLOGY FOLLOWS ACCESS

ADMITTED WITHOUT RESERVATION

- External perception (bāhya-pratyakṣa): colours, sounds, tastes, smells, touches, bodies and material processes
- Internal perception (mānasa or antara-pratyakṣa): pleasure, pain, desire and conscious states

REFUSED INDEPENDENT STANDING

- Inference (anumāna) — it moves beyond what is immediately given
- Verbal testimony (śabda) — trust in a speaker plus an inference from words to facts
- Comparison (upamāna), postulation (arthāpatti) and non-cognition (anupalabdhi) inherit the same objection

THE FIVE-STEP ARGUMENT

- Knowledge must be grounded in the immediately given; only perception gives its object immediately
- Inference outruns the given and testimony is derivative, so neither is basic
- Therefore perception alone is an independent means of valid knowledge, and only perceptible entities may be admitted into being

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Epistemic access fixes ontological commitment, so the metaphysics of the school is generated rather than separately chosen.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The thesis is that perception is the only independent means of valid knowledge, which is far stronger than the uncontroversial claim that perception is merely the primary source of knowledge.

03

STAGE 03 THE ATTACK ON INFERENCE: THREE CLOSED DOORS

INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (VYĀPTI) | DOOR 1 — FINITE SURVEY | DOOR 2 — CIRCULARITY OR REGRESS | DOOR 3 — UNPROVED TESTIMONY | TRUTH IS ACCIDENTAL | HABIT, NOT WARRANT

EVERY INFERENCE NEEDS AN UNRESTRICTED UNIVERSAL: wherever smoke, there fire → **NOT BY PERCEPTION — past, future and distant cases are never surveyed** → **NOT BY INFERENCE — a further concomitance is needed, so the proof is circular or regressive** → **NOT BY TESTIMONY — its own validity is unproved and is itself inferred** → **THEREFORE the universal never rises above habit, expectation or probability**

WHAT IS CONCEDED

- People constantly move from a sign to what it signifies, and often reach a true conclusion
- Sharma's reductio on testimony: if testimony grounded the universal, none would be able to infer anything by himself

WHAT IS DENIED

- That such movement yields necessary, exceptionless knowledge
- That predictive success confers status, since some inferences are true only accidentally and truth is separable from the practice

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The three doors must appear visibly as three, because a vague statement that the universal cannot be proved throws away the marks this argument carries.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Inference is refused the status of a means of valid knowledge because its indispensable universal can be reached neither by perception, nor by inference, nor by testimony without circularity or an unproved assumption.

04

STAGE 04 HIDDEN CONDITION AND THE SOCRATES SYLLOGISM

HIDDEN LIMITING CONDITION (UPĀDHI) | FIRE PLUS WET FUEL | STRUCTURAL, NOT QUANTITATIVE | FORM CONCEDED VALID | MAJOR PREMISE IS THE TARGET | VALID BUT EMPTY

AN OBSERVED REGULARITY MAY TRACK AN UNNOTICED FURTHER CONDITION

Repeated observation of smoke with fire invites a hasty universal → **What was constant may have been fire together with wet fuel, so the universal was too broad all along**

WHY THE OBJECTION IS STRUCTURAL

- Incomplete enumeration is quantitative and could in principle be reduced by more observation
- An unnoticed qualifier survives however extensive the observation becomes, so constancy can never certify unconditionality

APPLIED TO THE SOCRATES SYLLOGISM (2019)

- The Cārvāka does not attack the form: if the premises hold, the conclusion follows
- The target is the major premise, 'All men are mortal', which functions exactly as an invariable concomitance
- Relocating the relation to man-ness and mortality fails, because class-characters are not perceived either

THE VERDICT TO WRITE

- The syllogism is valid but epistemically empty: it transmits a certainty that was never independently acquired

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Stating only the incomplete-survey point leaves the stronger half of the case unwritten, because the qualifier objection is what actually defeats unconditionality.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The hidden limiting condition shows that observed constancy cannot certify unconditionality, which is why the Cārvāka attacks the major premise of a syllogism rather than its form.

05

STAGE 05 SELF-REFUTATION AND THE THREE REPLIES

THE DENIAL IS ITSELF A UNIVERSAL | OTHER MINDS ARE NEVER PERCEIVED | DESTRUCTIVE DEBATE (VITAṆḌĀ) | SOFTENED THESIS | LEVEL-DISTINCTION | RADICAL OR CONSISTENT, NOT BOTH

THE CHARGE, IN STEPS

- 'No inference is a means of valid knowledge' quantifies over every inferential act
- No single perception delivers a universal, so the thesis is either inferred or undefended
- Sharma presses further: thoughts and other minds are never perceived, so the Cārvāka can understand others only through inference

THE THREE REPLIES

- Destructive debate: advance no thesis at all — but four elements and a body-self are in fact asserted
- Softened thesis: deny apodictic certainty, especially about the transcendent — defensible, but a weaker doctrine
- Level-distinction: concede everyday validity and deny ultimate validity — though Sharma notes this distinction is unknown to the Cārvāka

WHERE JAYARĀŚI STANDS

- A purely destructive dialectic needs no rival theory, so the charge bites least against him
- Residual worry: even destructive reasoning assumes that destructive reasoning is reliable

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The charge is that the position is internally unstable, which is a far stronger objection than the familiar complaint that it is merely impractical.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Cārvāka may be radical or consistent but not both, since the unrestricted denial of inference is self-defeating while the softened denial of certainty is a much weaker doctrine.

06

STAGE 06 THE NYĀYA RECONSTRUCTION AND THE WARRANT SHIFT

AGREEMENT IN PRESENCE AND ABSENCE | ELIMINATION OF SUSPECTED CONDITIONS | HYPOTHETICAL REASONING (TARKA) | PERCEPTION OF THE UNIVERSAL | PARĀMARŚA SECURES INDEPENDENCE | WARRANT WITHOUT ENTAILMENT

REPEATED CO-OBSERVATION of the probans with the probandum (anvaya) → **ABSENCE of the probans wherever the probandum is absent (vyatireka)** → **SYSTEMATIC ELIMINATION of suspected hidden conditions** → **HYPOTHETICAL REASONING removes doubt, though it is not itself a means of valid knowledge** → **THE MARK COGNISED AS QUALIFIED (parāmarśa) — neither a fresh perception nor a report, hence independent**

THE REAL LOCUS OF THE DISPUTE

- Both sides agree that finite observation cannot entail an unrestricted universal
- Cārvāka concludes that there is no knowledge; Nyāya answers that warrant does not require entailment
- The quarrel is therefore about the concept of knowledge, not about the logic of induction

HONEST RESIDUE AGAINST NYĀYA

- Hypothetical reasoning establishes nothing on its own and can only remove doubt
- Perception of the universal is defensible only inside Nyāya realism about universals, so it is not a neutral answer
- Elimination removes only suspected conditions and never proves that none remains

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Nyāya answers by redefinition rather than by refutation, conceding the logical point and denying only the epistemological conclusion drawn from it.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nyāya defeats the strong thesis by replacing omniscient certainty with disciplined and defeasible warrant, which is precisely the fallibilist position a refined Cārvāka could accept.

07

STAGE 07 TESTIMONY REFUSED AND THE LEDGER OF SOURCES

SOUND IS PERCEIVED, CONTENT IS NOT | SUPPRESSED RELIABILITY PREMISE | AS PRECARIOUS AS INFERENCE | CĀRVĀKA FIXES THE LOWER BOUND | STANDING OPPONENT'S POSITION

SCHOOL	MEANS ADMITTED	WHAT IT ADDS TO THE PREVIOUS ROW
Cārvāka	One	Perception alone — the minimum of the shared ledger
Vaiśeṣika and Buddhism	Two	Inference
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	Three	Verbal testimony
Nyāya	Four	Comparison
Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā	Five	Postulation
Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā and Advaita	Six	Non-apprehension

WHY TESTIMONY FAILS

- Testimony reports only that someone uttered something; the step to truth needs an unstated premise about competence and honesty
- That premise is inferred, and inference has already been refused independent standing
- Claims of Vedic authorlessness and infallibility are not perceptually available

WHAT IS NOT DENIED

- Ordinary communication continues, and language may guide action until perception checks it
- Usefulness is separated from the status of a means of valid knowledge

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Every richer epistemology must justify its additions against the Cārvāka minimum, which is why the school functions as the standing opponent's position of Indian philosophy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Verbal testimony collapses into an inference about a speaker, so the school occupies the lower bound of a shared ledger against which every other Indian epistemology defends its additions.

08

STAGE 08 MATERIAL ONTOLOGY: FOUR ELEMENTS AND OWN NATURE

EARTH · WATER · FIRE · AIR | ETHER (ĀKĀŚA) REJECTED | NEVER WRITE FIVE ELEMENTS | OWN NATURE (SVABHĀVAVĀDA) | CHANCE (YADṚCCHĀVĀDA) CONTESTED | 2020 Q6(b) ANCHOR

THE FOURFOLD BASE

- Earth, water, fire and air are eternal material bases whose combination and dissolution produce bodies, sense organs, objects and organisms
- Ether is rejected because it is not perceived; the inference from sound to an imperceptible substratum inherits the disputed problem of concomitance

OWN NATURE AGAINST CHANCE

- Own-nature explanation denies transcendent causation while preserving real regularity: fire burns, water flows down, thorns are sharp, the peacock is variegated
- Chance-theory denies determinate causation altogether and is listed among causeless views attacked by Buddhists, Jainas and Naiyāyikas alike
- The association of chance-theory with Cārvāka is contested and must be flagged rather than asserted

OBJECTION AND REPLY

- Objection: 'it burns by its own nature' is a refusal to explain rather than an explanation
- Reply: every explanatory chain terminates somewhere, and this terminus is at least observable, unlike divine will or unseen moral force
- Residual force: the school still gives no account of why natures remain stable

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The perceptual criterion is applied to cosmology exactly as strictly as it is applied to theology, which is what removes the fifth element.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Only four elements are admitted because ether is never perceived, and regularity is explained by the observable natures of things rather than by any unseen moral or divine order.

09

STAGE 09 SELF, BODY AND EMERGENT AWARENESS

BODY-SELF (DEHĀTMAVĀDA) | I AM STOUT · I AM THIN | BETEL AND FERMENTATION | EMERGENCE, NOT IDENTITY | FOUR SELF-MODELS CONTESTED | EXPLANATORY GAP REMAINS

THE POSITIVE THESIS

- Conscious life is only ever met with as embodied, and no self is perceived apart from bodily states
- Identity-language predicates bodily properties directly of the person; the reply that 'my body' separates possessor from possessed is met by noting that possessive grammar proves no separable substance
- Injury, intoxication, age, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness

HOW AWARENESS ARISES

- Betel leaf, lime and areca nut together give a red colour present in no ingredient separately
- Fermenting agents give an intoxicating power that none of them carries alone
- The claim is emergence in an organised whole, never identity with any single element
- Reported materialist candidates for the self — gross body, senses, vital processes and mind — all perish with the living complex

OBJECTIONS AND THE HONEST LIMIT

- Jaina objection: an emergent property still needs a bearer; Advaita objection: consciousness is self-luminous and the body is known by it
- Reply: positing an immaterial soul renames the difficulty rather than explaining it
- Limit: redness and intoxicating power are third-personal, whereas awareness is first-personal, so emergence is asserted rather than explained

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Cārvāka relocates the self into matter while Buddhism dissolves it, so the two denials of the self are different in kind rather than in degree.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The living conscious body is the self, and awareness is an emergent property of that organised body, which is why the school denies transcendence while still keeping a bearer of personhood.

10

STAGE 10 THE REJECTION OF TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES

ONE TEMPLATE, MANY DENIALS | SOUL · REBIRTH · KARMA · ADṚṢṬA | HEAVEN · HELL · ĪŚVARA · VEDA | DEATH ITSELF IS LIBERATION | RITUAL CRITIQUE IS SUPPLEMENTARY | 2021 Q5(e) ANCHOR

X IS IMPERCEPTIBLE → ONLY INFERENCE OR TESTIMONY COULD REACH X → NEITHER IS INDEPENDENT → X IS NOT ADMITTED

Applied to the soul, rebirth and transmigration, moral residue (karma and adṛṣṭa) and post-mortem reward → **Applied to heaven and hell, the creator (Īśvara), Vedic infallibility and liberation (mokṣa)**

LIBERATION IS CANCELLED, NOT REDESCRIBED

- The opponent-preserved formula 'death itself is liberation' means that dissolution ends the person and therefore ends suffering
- It describes no positive post-mortem state and must not be quoted as a Cārvāka definition of release

THE RITUAL CRITIQUE, KEPT IN ITS PLACE

- Promised unseen ritual results cannot be verified, which is the epistemological objection
- The satire that ritual sustains priestly livelihood, and the mocking challenge about the sacrificial victim, are polemical supplements and never the main argument

OBJECTION AND STRUCTURAL VERDICT

- Objection: without moral residue and rebirth the moral order collapses
- Reply: pleasure, pain, prudence and social consequence are enough for conduct without cosmic bookkeeping
- Cārvāka is the only Indian school whose atheism follows from its epistemology rather than from cosmology or soteriology

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Because one criterion does all the work, the denials cannot be evaluated piecemeal and an opponent who saves inference recovers the whole supersensible order at once.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The rejection of transcendent entities is not an independent metaphysical preference but the ontological consequence of restricting valid knowledge to perception.

11

STAGE 11 ETHICS, SOCIETY AND ANTI-CARICATURE CONTROL

PLEASURE (KĀMA) IS THE END | WEALTH (ARTHA) IS THE MEANS | HUSK AND GRAIN | STATECRAFT AND LIVELIHOOD | CRUDE VERSUS REFINED CONTESTED | PRUDENCE, NOT MORALITY

FOUR HUMAN ENDS ENTER THE FILTER → **Scriptural duty (dharma) is rejected where it rests on command or unseen reward** → **Liberation (mokṣa) is rejected because it presupposes a separable self and a post-mortem destiny** → **Wealth (artha) survives as the instrument and pleasure (kāma) survives as the end** → **Prudential rule: secure pleasure while limiting foreseeable pain, as grain is not discarded for its husk**

THE SOCIAL READING — THIN EVIDENCE

- Statecraft (daṇḍanīti) and livelihood (vārttā) are reported inside the Lokāyata curriculum, and some Cārvākas are said to regard the king as God
- The natural reading is a secular theory of authority in which order comes from the sovereign rather than from cosmic duty
- The evidence is doxographical and must be presented as suggestive rather than established

CRUDE AND REFINED, HANDLED SAFELY

- Later doxographers distinguish a crude from a refined Cārvāka, and the refined form admits worldly inference
- The refined form supplies the strongest reply to the self-refutation charge
- They must never be presented as two documented schools with surviving texts and named teachers

THE HONEST EVALUATION

- Two things the rivals supply are missing: a qualitative ranking of pleasures and an account of other-regarding obligation
- The verdict to write is a coherent theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The traditional pleasure verse may be used for colour, but it is a doxographical line and never a quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka ethics ranks pleasure as the end and wealth as its instrument, so it is prudential this-worldliness rather than the reckless indulgence of the hostile caricature.

12

STAGE 12 SYNTHESIS: COMPARISON, PYQ RAIL AND ANSWER SPINE

NINE OWNED PYQS, 2018-2025 | ONE COMPARISON, ARGUED | CRITERION-NAMED VERDICT | 10 · 15 · 20 MARK ROUTES | NO FLAT YES OR NO | TOUCHSTONE OF THE SYSTEMS

DEFINE and flag reconstruction → STATE the perception-only criterion → **ARGUE the three doors and the hidden condition → ANSWER with the Nyāya reply and its residues** → **DERIVE four elements, the body-self, emergent awareness and the transcendent denials** → **COMPARE one rival school on fixed axes → CONCLUDE with a verdict that names its criterion**

COMPARATIVE AXES TO USE

- Knowledge: perception only, against four means in Nyāya, two in Buddhist epistemology and standpoint-conditioned plurality in Jainism
- Self: the living body, against an enduring self, against no substantial self, against plural souls
- Liberation: death ends the person, against release, cessation and the liberation of the soul
- Buddhism rules out the body-self by name, because material form is itself an aggregate declared not-self

THE PYQ RAIL

- 2018 Q8(b), 2019 Q5(c), 2019 Q6(c), 2020 Q6(b), 2020 Q7(c), 2021 Q5(e), 2024 Q5(a), 2024 Q6(a) and 2025 Q5(a) are directly owned
- The 2022 Q7(c) Nyāya question is the mirror image and is answered from the same material
- No owned part appears in 2022 or 2023, so the topic is examined in bursts and must stay revision-ready

THE GRADED VERDICT

- Chatterjee and Datta: the school became the touchstone on which every other system tested its theories
- Sharma: born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought — the two verdicts together give the balance examiners reward
- Ten marks: strongest as an epistemological protest, weakest when the denial becomes absolute
- Twenty marks: the dogmatic wing is vulnerable, the refined wing is a coherent empiricist restriction, and Jayarāśi's wing is a serious destructive dialectic

MECHANISM / VERDICT — A flat verdict earns little, so the conclusion must name the standard by which the school succeeds and the standard by which it fails.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka should be judged as a single argument rather than a list of denials, because restricting valid knowledge to perception removes the soul, moral residue, rebirth, heaven, the creator and liberation from the world together.

E

EXTRA OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT: CONTROLLED MODERN COMPARISON

HUME ON UNIVERSAL CONNECTION | AYER ON VERIFIABILITY | EPICURUS ON THIS-WORLDLY PLEASURE | ONE CLAUSE AT MOST

POINTS OF CONTACT

- Hume also questions whether observed conjunction establishes a necessary universal connection
- Ayer also rejects unverifiable metaphysics, and his verification principle faces its own self-refutation charge
- Epicurus also grounds value in this-worldly pleasure and rejects fear-based religion

DECISIVE DISANALOGIES

- Hume keeps inductive reasoning as the guide of life; Cārvāka withdraws its status as a means of valid knowledge
- Ayer's claim is semantic and preserves scientific theory; the Cārvāka claim is epistemic and threatens science too
- Epicurean pleasure is ascetic and calculative, aimed at tranquillity, unlike straightforward embodied enjoyment

OPTIONAL STATUS — This comparative material is unnecessary for a competent core answer and belongs in at most one qualifying clause after the Indian argument is complete.

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